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P.M.'S SPEECH FROM RED FORT

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1892
August 15, 1970

Speaking from the ramparts of the Red Fort on the occasion of the 24th anniversary of the Independence Day today, the Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi, said that the people of the country were never so conscious and alert as they were today. All the political parties and the people had started giving deep thoughts to many problems facing the country.

Due to a variety of reasons, Shrimati Gandhi added we had not been able to march forward as speedily as we wished but even this progress had made certain elements restless. But there was no caus for worry and anxiety.

The Prime Minister went on to say that the cardinal principle of India's foreign policy is world peace and this policy is now being adopted by other nations. In this context, she referred to the acceptance of the US peace proposals for West Asia by the United Arab Republic. She said that President Nasser had displayed courage and commonsense in accepting these proposals. Similarly, she said Soviet Russia and West Germany who had a long-time animosity and who even went to war had signed a non-aggression pact. The Prime Minister also referred to the latest move of the U.K. Government to give arms aid to South Africa. She said that this step would prove dangerous for the independent neighbouring countries of South Africa. She hoped that the U.K. would reconsider her policy.

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Following is the free translation of the speech delivered in Hindi;

Citizens of India, brothers and sisters and our enthusiast youngmen,

Today, our independent India is entering into the twentyfourth year of its life. Every year on the bank of the Yamuna at this Red Fort, the people and their servants get an opportunity to meet each other. I feel that this meeting gives strength to all of us. Nearabout the last Independence Day and subsequently great changes have taken place in our country. All the political parties and the people of India have started giving deep thoughts to many problems. All of us are trying to explain our policies and exploring new ways. Our people have got an opportunity to make our democracy mature. They have got an opportunity to examine the achievements and also to decide what steps they have to take in future and after due deliberations decide to take new decisions.

Many programmes which were stopped either because of war or drought or due to certain other reasons or because of economic recession have been revived. On the one hand we are marching forward and on the other certain forces, which, because of these reasons, had grown strong are feeling perturbed by the speed of this forward march and they have opposed and are opposing the steps we have taken towards the progress. But I know that the people are aware what is

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right and what is wrong. What is good and what is bad. They have this capacity to discriminate between good and evil. The real meaning of democracy consists in this strength of the people and that the real power should be in the hands of the people.

All of you know that since long before I was elected to this office, I have been touring the four corners of this country. But never before have I found our people so much awakened, so conscious and so much alert as they are today. Never before have I seen so many hopes aroused in their hearts and their awareness of their rights and their readiness for the new changes as was noticed during the last one year. This is both a good sign and a great challenge to us. We have to face this challenge. Just as I had said many programmes which could not be implemented are now being carried out. Production of both agriculture and industry has increased. The nationalisation of banks has thrown open new avenues for the people, particularly for the youth of the country. Though it is more than a year since the nationalisation of banks took place but the fruits of it have started accruing to the people only during the last few months. As you know, this matter was pending before the Supreme Court and this was the reason why its implementation was delayed.

Alongside....

Alongside we hear strange slogans being raised. Some people talk of violence but violence has so far not solved any problem. However, noble may be our objectives, if we adopt wrong means we cannot achieve our objectives satisfactorily. I had thought that the debate between violence and non-violence had already been settled in our country. We had disapproved during the course of our struggle for independence the belief of the people who thought that our country could not achieve independence through non-violence, we proved it to the world that it was possible through non-violence and I want to assure you also that even economic progress can be achieved through non-violance and that all the big changes in the country can be brought about by non-violent means. It is our duty that we should rise above the slogan-mongering and unitedly we should find our ways and means through which we can do some solid work. Some of our youngmen think that they have discovered a new way of revolution. I will appeal to them to see first as to which way lies the interests of their country, whether it can be achieved by raising solgans or by indulging in destruction and sabotage. I can understand the disappointment and restlessness which is felt by the young generation and I do believe that restlessness is not always a bad sign.

We are today facing some big problems. Prices have increased. This is in fact a big problem. Also, there is

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the problem of unemployment. When the prices rise the people feel the pinch of it, particularly those who belong to the fixed income groups and also the workers. All these people feel great difficulty. I know this and I am very much worried on this account. But you have also to appreciate the fact that when a nation goes forward the prices go up to certain extent. It is our duty to see that the prices of essential commodities are stabilised and prevent them from rising. We have to strike a balance between the incomes and the prices. This is our duty. At the same time we know that when prices of foodgrains go down our peasants and those living in the rural areas are adversely affected and to certain extent this adds to their burden. Therefore, we have to very carefully weigh every issue and then have to find a middle path so that if there is any suffering or misery, it should be evenly distributed, and that nobody suffers more than the other. We are seriously exercised with the problem of those who have every thing in excess, whether it is urban property or anything else. We had alrea announced that we are going to take some action in this matter. Now, we propose to do it more expeditiously, and I have every hope that we would be able to do something this direction very soon. We have also to be careful th with the march forward there is no set back to our production and that our pace of progress is not slowed

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down, because if our production goes down or if the pace of our progress is slowed down, then our hands which are able to help the poor and the down-trodden, will be weakened considerably. Therefore, we have always to strike the balance. I know that many people feel uncomfortable on this account by this and they have a feelings that the country is not going ahead with the speed with which it ought to have moved on. But I am confident that the path we have chosen is bound to accelerate our progress and by taking new steps we would be able to explore new ways for marching forward.

When I talk of restlessness, I mean that it is a feeling of dissatisfaction against the status quo. We want to change it, we want to improve it and this is a good feeling. But if guided by this feeling we indulge in sabotage and destruction, then it will not be either in the interests of the young nor it will be to the advantage of the country. On the contrary it will do serious harm to the country and the objectives that we want to achieve will be frustrated and perhaps we will be thrown back in our forward march. So this is not the time to get ourselves involved in petty thinking but to think of big changes. Gandhiji and Nehru had shown us the way how big changes can be brought about in the country on the strength of the people. When I was 13 years old, my father wrote to me from jail and had given me this advice - he had written that nothing should be done in secrecy. Do not do anything which you had to conceal from others; do it....

and in full light
do it in the open/and he had told me that how under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi we had launched an independence movement for our country and this movement was a perennial source of strength to all the people, weak and strong, and they can launch and carry on this independence movement through non-violent means. We have to keep all this before ourselves and all institutions, all the people of the country had not to do anything which is to be concealed from others but we should do everything in the open. This is the real meaning of democracy. If we do it in the open, then it will be much easier to bring about changes in our country because the people will be able to understand and appreciate the way, and therefore all the people of the country will accord their heartiest cooperation in the venture.

Our economic condition has considerably improved. This does not mean that our problems have been lessened. There has been progress and along with it our problems have also multiplied. Both of them exist in our country. Progress creates problems and sometimes problems show the way for progress. Therefore, we should not be frightened although we have to convert them into power - that power which will take us forward unitedly. Our problems are like a mountain, and we cannot afford to look back and see how far we have climbed but we have only to think how much remains to be climbed.

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For that we have to rally ourselves together. Similarly, we have to stabilise the prices and if there are some commodities the prices of which could not be controlled, we have to endure them. Similarly, we have to increase the employment opportunities for our young men. Many avenues have been suggested, some within the Plan and some outside the Plan. I believe that our youngmen will take advantage of this and thereby explore new ways so that they can stand on their own feet and can be self-reliant. This is possible to achieve as the people of all the advanced countries have done the same. They do not depend on anybody for these things because there are historical reasons for their advancement. Now those considerations are changing and along with them our youngmen have also to change and they have to decide how they have to change the society and thereby ensure the progress of all the people of the country. We have started working in this direction. Some are receiving assistance from the banks and some through other sources and, I believe that all these schemes will be implemented and will be an effective instrument in providing employment to the unemployed youngmen of the country. It is true that everybody cannot at once get a suitable employment but we know that when the journey is long and ardous, we have always to reach our destination step by step. We have taken many steps on this journey with enthusiasm and courage and when our youngmen join us in this journey they would be able to take us all forward in a much speedier way. There is need for economic and.....

economic and social transformation but alongside there are certain other difficulties which come in the way. Recently, there was a new problem. A new slogan has been raised - the slogan 'Land-Grab'. I do not want to say anything at length about this on this occasion.

But I will confine myself to saying only this much that some people have got too much of land whereas some have no land at all. This state of affairs can in no way be called justice. It is our duty to introduce justice in the society. We have taken some steps in this direction which have ensured some relief to some people. It is our duty to see that the Acts which were passed with this end in view are urgently enforced whether it is to be done by the Central Government or by the State Governments but this must be done honestly and effectively. The Central Government are doing their best to persuade the State Governments to implement these reforms speedily and thereby discharge their responsibility. The necessary

legislations.....